



Courtship gift

For European bee-eaters, the bond between male and female is often sealed with gifts of food. Here, a male offers his partner a butterfly, which he has caught in midair. His behavior is partly triggered by the female. She begs for food by opening her beak and fluttering her wings—behavior that imitates a young bird. During their courtship, the male presents the female with dozens of meals a day, giving her the energy she needs for making and laying her eggs.